

Introduction to the Human Sciences End-Semester Exam
Sociology Module

3 May 2026
Total Marks: 40

Time: 45 minutes

Answer the following questions

Question 1 (15 Marks, 400 words)

What is the Weber's typology of social action (4 marks)? Explain Weber's understanding of bureaucracy and its role in modern societies using this typology (11 marks).

The answer should look at Weber's use of rationalisation to understand large-scale social processes in the West. (Refer to Slides of Lecture 3 on Weber).

Weber came up with a 'typology' of social action – 1) instrumental rational action (purposeful or goal-oriented rational action), 2) value rational action (rational action in relation to certain set of values), 3) traditional action (action dictated by beliefs and customs which become habitual) and 4) affective action (actions driven by emotions). Award 1 mark if each type of action is mentioned and elaborated.

Weber essentially argues that in the modern world, instrumental rationality emerges as the primary type of social action, and that this shows up in both personal and public spheres. The role of bureaucracy is a good example of the manifestation of the theme of rationalization in the public/social sphere. Bureaucracy, through ensuring division of labour with chains of command, duties assigned and strictly demarcated, impersonal authority, abstract rules, and politically neutral (in theory), is the State's instrumental rational way of ensuring legitimacy. These rules, well-defined and applicable to all, allow for the exercise of authority, by appearing as 'instrumental rational' (6).

In other words, in modern society, there is the privileging of rationality. Bureaucracy is the example of this. Bureaucracy has at its core the clash between instrumental-rationality (formal rationality) and value-rationality (substantive rationality). Bureaucracy comes to dominate, instrumental rationality thrives at the expense of value-oriented rationality. Behaviour in modern societies comes to be dictated more by goal-oriented rationality and less and less by tradition, values or emotions (very important). Mechanisation and division of labour are also other features of this process of rationalisation. (5 marks if all this is mentioned).

Question 2 (15 marks, 400 words)

How do Karl Marx and Weber differ in their understanding of how capitalism emerges as a system?

Karl Marx and Max Weber offer two of the most influential yet contrasting explanations of the emergence of capitalism. While both recognise capitalism as a historically specific social system, they differ fundamentally in what they consider its driving force.

For Karl Marx, capitalism emerges primarily from material and economic transformations. In works such as Capital, Marx argues that history develops through changes in the mode of production and struggles between social classes. Capitalism arose when feudal relations broke down and new property relations enabled private ownership of the means of production. Processes such as enclosure, colonial expansion, and the accumulation of wealth created a class of capitalists who owned productive resources and a proletariat forced to sell labour power for wages. Thus, capitalism is rooted in economic structure and class conflict. Ideas, culture, and religion are largely shaped by these underlying material conditions. For Marx, capitalism's emergence is therefore structural and conflict-driven, propelled by contradictions within earlier economic systems (6)

In contrast, Max Weber emphasises the role of culture, ideas, and rationalisation in capitalism's rise. In The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism, Weber argues that capitalism required not only markets and technology but also a distinctive moral orientation toward work, profit, and discipline. He traces this "spirit of capitalism" to Protestant—especially Calvinist—religious ethics that valued hard work, frugality, and systematic reinvestment. These cultural motivations encouraged individuals to pursue profit rationally and continuously, helping to institutionalise capitalist enterprise. Weber therefore rejects economic determinism: capitalism emerged from the interaction between religious beliefs, legal institutions, bureaucratic organisation, and rational calculation (6)

The key difference lies in causality. Marx sees capitalism as arising from transformations in material production that subsequently shape ideology and social life. Weber reverses the emphasis, showing how ideas and ethical worldviews can actively enable economic change. While Marx explains capitalism through class relations and exploitation, Weber highlights cultural meaning and rational social organisation. Together, their perspectives reveal capitalism as both an economic system grounded in material relations and a cultural formation sustained by particular values and institutions (3).

Question 3 (10 marks, 250 words)

Who conceived the idea of social fact (2 marks)? What do you mean by social fact? Explain using an example (8 marks).

2 marks for who conceived the idea of social fact (Emile Durkheim). (Refer to Slides of Lecture 3 on Durkheim).

8 marks for explaining social fact. There should be two points in the definition of social fact – externality (social fact is outside of individuals) and constraint (social fact is coercive). Social fact is both material and immaterial. So 4 award marks for each of these points. Full marks should be awarded for each point only if a couple of lines of explanation is included in the answer. i.e. WHAT do we mean by social fact is coercive, what do we mean by social fact is external to the individual.

Question for the Optional Section (20 Marks)

What is Sociology? (3 marks) What are the three distinct phases of development of Sociology in India? (3 marks) Describe these phases briefly. (14 marks)

What is Sociology?

- Understanding the broader relationship between individuals and the larger society around them (1 mark)
- Theorizing societies: role of social structures, institutions, and cultures (1 mark)
- Study of societies (0.5 mark)
- Studying individuals and groups (0.5 mark)

What are the Three Distinct Phases of Development of Sociology in India?

- Colonial Modernity and Anthropology (1 mark)
- Nation State and the Formation of a 'National Sociology' (Social Anthropology) (1 mark)
- Post-1970s: The Period of Multiple Challenges (1 mark)

Describe These Phases Briefly

Phase I: Colonial Modernity and Anthropology (6 marks)

Sociology in the West and Anthropology in the East (2 marks)

- Belief in the superiority of 'Western' civilisation and continuous growth of capitalism through modernisation, development, and the creation of new markets.
- The 'West' was associated with 'history, reason, and science'; the 'East' with 'nature, religion, and spirituality'.

Anthropology as the Handmaiden of Colonialism (1 mark)

Lack of knowledge of the colonies was seen as an impediment to colonial rule.

- British records of the non-West were maintained by colonial officers as well as trained anthropologists.
- Colonies were studied as static, traditional, pre-modern, and non-civilized societies.

Classification and Fieldwork (1 mark)

- Categorization and classification of colonial societies was undertaken through the study of individual communities, with detailed accounts of languages, behavior, social practices, and customs.

- Region-wise analysis (ethnographic fieldwork) led to the creation of spatial-cultural zones to facilitate colonial rule.

Governance and Planning (1 mark)

- Revenue settlements introduced spatial categories such as villages, estates, and properties with zamindars, rajas, chiefs, and nawabs.
- Villages were depicted as self-sustaining units in which castes lived harmoniously.
- Caste and tribe were emphasized, while other interdependent and ever-changing social groups were overlooked.

Formal Education (1 mark)

- Teaching of Sociology began in 1919 at the University of Bombay. By 1947, only three universities — Bombay, Calcutta, and Lucknow — taught Sociology and/or Anthropology, with small centres in Poona, Mysore, and Hyderabad.
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Phase II: Nation State and the Formation of a 'National Sociology' (Social Anthropology)

Main Thinkers (1 mark): M.N. Srinivas and A.R. Desai

M.N. Srinivas (2.5 marks, 0.5 marks each)

- Srinivas emphasized 'civilisational' continuity, focusing on the caste system and studying 'traditional structure' in the village. While Ghurye used Indology to define caste, Srinivas used the field view — the empirical method of ethnography — to study the caste system.
- Used the village as the primary setting; divided the village population by caste and occupation.
- Examined the relationship between various castes and their occupations in the Indian agricultural system, presenting a 'harmonious' village system as the defining feature of Indian society.
- Identified a methodological confusion between 'caste' and 'village'.
- Excluded tribes, religious and ethnic groups (other than caste), and emerging interest groups.
- Distinguished between the subject (the ethnographer-researcher) and the object (the researched), but refused to examine the relationship between the two.
- Analysed general changes in the caste system through the concepts of Sanskritisation and Westernisation.
- Naturalised the 'traditional' character of Indian society and institutionalised the 'Savarna' idea of the nation.

A.R. Desai (2.5 marks, 0.5 marks each)

- Adopted a Marxist approach to the study of Indian society.
- Analysed contemporary social change to assess how it benefitted only a few.
- Critiqued mainstream nationalism and its political projects; examined the nature of the ruling class.

- Assessed the relationship between nation and class, development planning, and the emergence of new classes in the agricultural and urban industrial sectors.
- Highlighted the emergence of social movements against dominant classes.
- Included those left out by dominant Savarna and upper-class culturist interpretations of society.
- Adopted an interdisciplinary approach, bringing the historical method and questions of political economy into sociology.

Phase III: Post-1970s — The Period of Multiple Challenges (2 marks)

- Crisis in higher education since the late 1960s, involving challenges of regional diversity and new entrants into the educational system. (0.5 Mark)
- Rise of social movements in the 1970s and 1980s. (0.5 mark)

Any two (2 marks)

- Growth of communalism and globalisation towards the end of the 1980s.
- Emergence of new perspectives in sociology: Subaltern Studies, post-colonial studies, and feminist, Adivasi, and Dalit critiques.
- Growth of interdisciplinary research and teaching, including media and cultural studies.